

Leveraging data, artificial intelligence and digital health in the WHO European Region

A year in review 2025



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European Region





Introduction

New digital technologies are transforming health care in the WHO European Region, and 2025 marked another important year in this ongoing journey. Throughout the year, the Division of Health Systems, through its Data, Artificial Intelligence and Digital Health (DDH) team *(1)*, supported Member States with missions, workshops, briefings and technical guidance aimed at strengthening

health systems and improving people's health. As countries continued to navigate the rapid technological change, The WHO Regional Office for Europe worked alongside them to ensure that digital transformation remained people centred, ethically grounded and aligned with the goal of leaving no one behind.

Health systems of the future: harnessing technology and innovation in health for everyone, everywhere

Across the Region, advances in artificial intelligence (AI), precision medicine and the use of data are reshaping how health services are delivered. These tools offer powerful opportunities to prevent, diagnose and treat disease but cannot replace the human connection at the core of care. As Europe faces a shrinking health workforce, rising demands for services and new health security threats, innovation in traditional care models has become increasingly necessary.

In February more than 700 representatives of Member States, partners, civil society, health-care workers and digital health leaders came together for a thematic hearing related to the development of the Second European Programme of Work (EPW2) (2), entitled “Health systems of the future: harnessing technology and innovation in health, for everyone, everywhere”. The event explored how digital and emerging technologies are influencing health systems across Europe and central Asia, and how these innovations

can best serve people and remain aligned with core health system values. Keynote contributions from ministers, thought leaders, experts and members of the WHO leadership helped to shape a shared understanding of the opportunities and challenges ahead.

In parallel, the Division contributed to the EPW2’s draft paper, *Leveraging data and technology: harnessing potential for everyone, everywhere* (3), which emphasizes that digital technologies and AI must be designed to serve people, improve access, strengthen systems and support more equitable decision-making. The work reinforces a principle that remains constant across the Regional Office’s digital transformation agenda: innovation must be guided by public purpose, supported by strong governance, grounded in trust and ethics, and implemented in ways that ensure that no one is left behind.

To learn more about the EPW2, watch the video *EPW2: Health systems of the future* (4).



The numbers

In 2025 the DDH team completed:

122

activities

15

missions to Member States

19

webinars, trainings and workshops

46

briefings and communication materials

24

documents on tools and technical guidance

1

country profile and stocktake presentation

Missions

15

missions providing support to 13 Member States

3

functional assessments

7

partner engagement activities

Tools and technical guidance

24

activities

9

tools related to WHO guidance, policy briefs and reports

4

activities linked to knowledge management

Events and meetings

40

different events, with 1204 participants

17

technical meetings

16

trainings and workshops

4

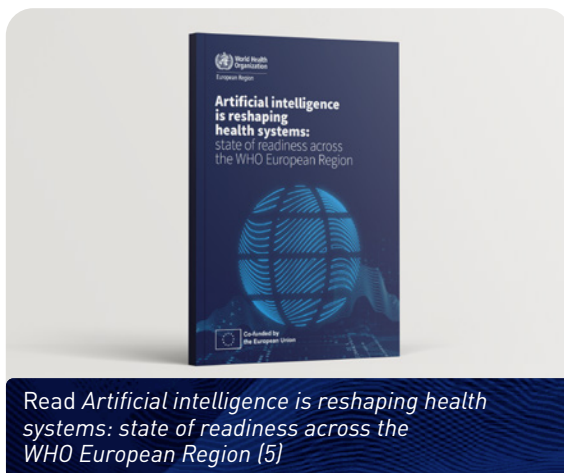
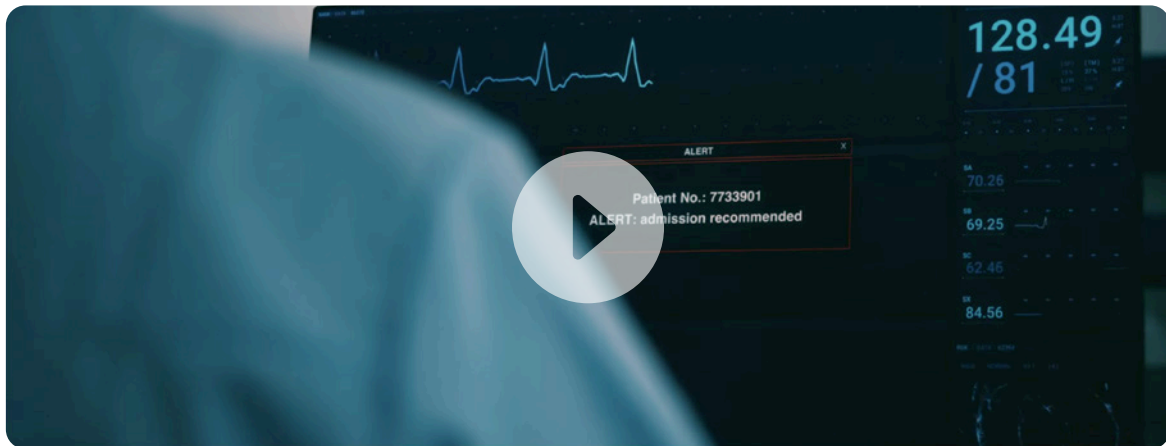
high-level events

22

bilateral meetings in countries

AI

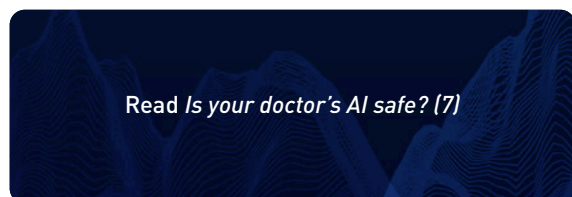
Watch the video *AI in health, empowering patients, enhancing care*, to learn more about AI use in health (5).



Read *Artificial intelligence is reshaping health systems: state of readiness across the WHO European Region* (5)

In 2025 AI continued to advance rapidly across the WHO European Region, supporting early diagnosis, reducing administrative burdens and improving communication between patients and health-care providers. However, this acceleration has exposed important gaps in legal and ethical safeguards. A new WHO Regional Office for Europe report, *Artificial intelligence is reshaping health systems: state of readiness across the WHO European Region* (6), is based on responses from 50 Member States. It provides the first comprehensive regional picture of how AI is being adopted and regulated. The findings highlight that, while AI is already widely used in clinical and administrative settings, many

countries still lack the liability protections and governance mechanisms needed to keep patients and health workers safe.



Read *Is your doctor's AI safe?* (7)

Complementing this work, a set of country profiles (8) explores how Member States are navigating the evolving AI landscape by examining strategic readiness, workforce capacity, regulatory environments, health data governance, practical applications and persistent barriers.



Read *Artificial intelligence is reshaping health systems: country profiles* (8)

To strengthen regional leadership, WHO is consulting Member States on establishing a Geographically Dispersed Office for AI (9), which would support countries to adopt safe, ethical and trustworthy AI systems. The proposed office would aim to ensure that the benefits of AI are shared equitably and that public health values remain central to innovation.

AI is also reshaping how public health authorities communicate during crises. A joint study (10) by the University of Zurich and the WHO Regional Office for Europe, published in BMJ Global Health, found that AI can help to manage misinformation and support risk communication during emergencies – but only when used responsibly and guided by strong ethical principles.

To provide expert guidance across these areas, the Regional Office launched the Technical Advisory Group on AI for Health (11) in September. The Group brings together specialists from across the Region to support the ethical, equitable and effective use of AI in domains ranging from clinical care and mental health to health systems strengthening, quality of care, genomics and public health.



Lastly, during the Seventy-fifth session of the WHO Regional Committee for Europe, the DDH team and the Information and Communications Technology Unit co-hosted a side event showcasing how AI is already improving organizational performance. Delegates heard opening remarks from Dr Hans Henri P. Kluge, WHO Regional Director for Europe, saw demonstrations of the Regional Office's AI tools and engaged with Member State representatives to discuss how AI can streamline workflows, enhance decision-making and strengthen the support that WHO provides to countries.



Data monitoring, analysis and evidence

European health report 2024: keeping health high on the agenda

The WHO European Region is long reputed to have some of the world's strongest health systems. However, despite progress in some areas, it is largely stagnating or even backsliding on a range of indicators from child and adolescent health to chronic diseases. That is the key message of WHO's latest European health report and accompanying highlights (12) (for 2024), which draws on the most recently available data across all 53 Member States spanning Europe and central Asia.

The European health report is produced every 3 years as a flagship publication of the WHO Regional Office for Europe. This latest edition is based on the indicators included in the WHO *European Programme of Work, 2020–2025 – “United Action for Better Health”* measurement framework (13).



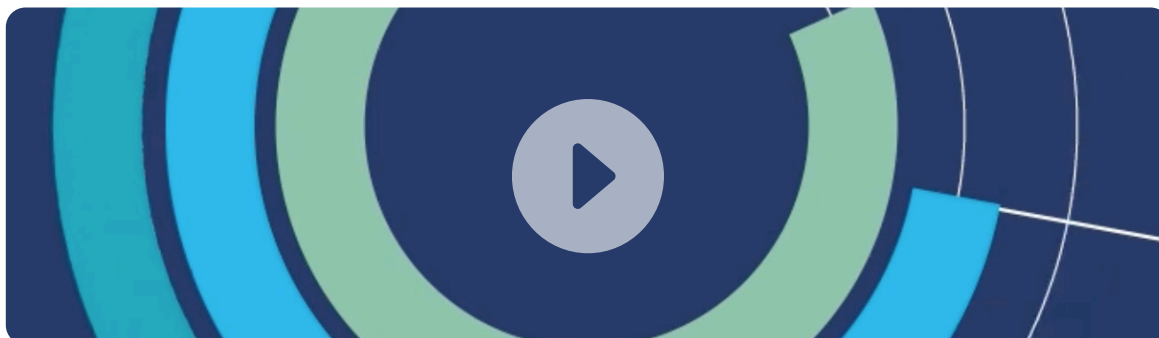
[Read European health report 2024 \(14\)](#)

We have made great strides in tackling noncommunicable diseases (NCDs) – the main cause of death in our Region. At least 10 Member States have met the WHO target of a 25% reduction in premature mortality from the four major NCDs. Tuberculosis has also been successfully addressed, with a 25% reduction in incidence and a 32% decrease in tuberculosis-related deaths between 2015 and 2022.

The Regional Director said “I am pleased to see that the European health report 2024 highlights several positive developments. Premature mortality caused by noncommunicable diseases is declining in the WHO European Region, as is suicide mortality; the incidence of tuberculosis is also decreasing. These and many other achievements reflect the ongoing commitment of Member States to improving the health and well-being of the nearly 1 billion people across the Region”.

EPW2 (2) which will come into effect in 2026, will be the main policy tool for the Region. It will outline how WHO and the Member States will address the challenges identified in this European health report 2024.

Watch the video *Keeping health high on the agenda: European health report 2024*, to learn more about the European health report 2024 (15).



Core health indicators in the WHO European Region 2025



Read *Core health indicators in the WHO European Region (16)*

Core health indicators in the WHO European Region 2025 (16) was published in October 2025. These indicators are essential for tracking

the health status and system performance of countries across the WHO European Region by providing a standardized, comparable foundation for evidence-informed decision-making. This year's edition draws on the latest data from Member States, complemented by WHO estimates where needed, to present a comprehensive picture of progress against WHO's Fourteenth General Programme of Work (17) indicators. Through visualizations, disaggregation by age and sex, and a focus on health equity, it offers governments and partners a practical tool for policy and investment planning.

Improving mortality data

High-quality mortality data are the backbone of population health monitoring. They are essential for understanding the disease burden, tracking progress towards national and regional health targets, and guiding evidence-informed policy decisions.

WHO continued to support countries to improve mortality reporting, including coronavirus disease (COVID-19) classifications, to ensure alignment with international standards. In the 2024–2025

data cycle, technical assistance enabled several Member States to update or fill gaps in their mortality datasets. New submissions were received from countries such as Albania, Armenia, Bulgaria, Estonia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Republic of Moldova, Slovenia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan. Notably, Turkmenistan reported new mortality data for the first time in two decades that are now being prepared for integration into regional analyses.

Health For All database

The annual update of the Health for All database (18) in the European Health Information Gateway was successfully completed: 618 indicators were validated and updated with the latest available data. The indicators cover basic demographics, health status, health determinants and risk factors, as well as health-care resources, expenditures and more.



European Health Information Network



The European Health Information Network (HIN) was established to guide the work under the WHO Regional Office for Europe and European Union (EU) partnership (19) to strengthen health information systems and boost data governance across the WHO European Region. It serves as a platform for exchange between Member States. By the end of 2025, HIN consisted of 99 representatives from 50 Member States.

In 2025 HIN convened three meetings, including one in-person meeting in Malta, to review progress under the EU-funded action and advance implementation of its workplan. The workplan addresses shared challenges in health information systems and data governance and guides the development of tools, standards and capacity-building support for Member States.

Central Asian republics information network



The central Asian republics information network (CARINFONET) (20) is a collaborative network of five countries in central Asia that provides a platform for improving health information systems.

The Sixth CARINFONET Steering Group meeting, held in Astana, Kazakhstan in

September 2025, focused on reviewing national progress, updating the CARNOFET's workplan, and discussing future priorities. It also marked the transfer of the CARINFONET chairmanship to Kazakhstan for a 2-year term.

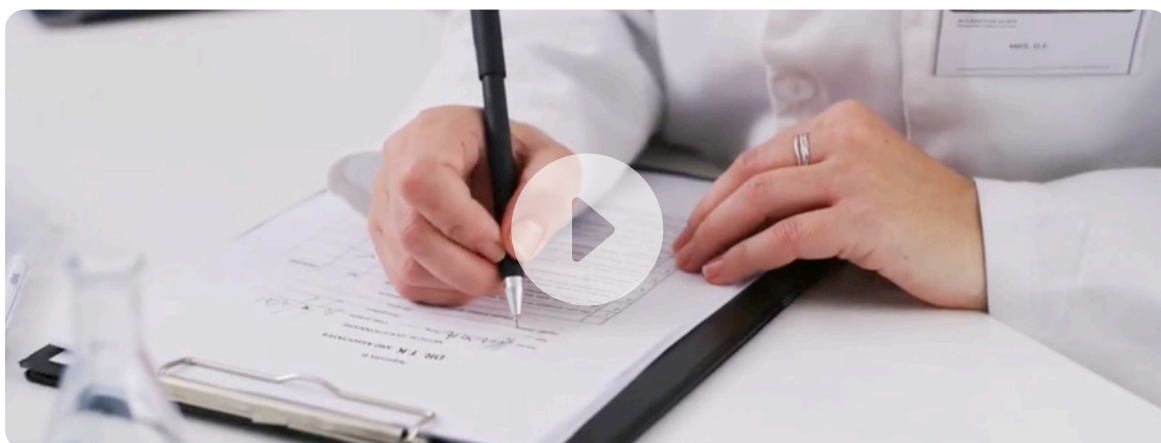
Evidence and knowledge translation



A regional consultation in Prague brought together more than 50 experts, policy-makers and researchers to strengthen the evidence ecosystem for clinical trials to build on resolution WHA75.8 (21) and its call for global guidance on scientifically and

ethically sound research. Participants from 25 countries, the European Commission, the European Medicines Agency and major trial networks shared their experiences and outlined a common vision for ethical, inclusive and AI-ready research in Europe.

Watch the video *Strengthening clinical research in Europe consultation*, to learn more about strengthening clinical research in Europe (22).



The WHO Regional Office for Europe also published new technical guidance on rapid response products (23) to help decision-makers to quickly access high-quality evidence in urgent policy and public health situations.

To further strengthen research governance, a subregional meeting with representatives

of Estonia, Latvia and Lithuania used the *WHO tool for benchmarking ethics oversight of health-related research involving human participants* (24) to assess national systems, identify gaps and enhance the capacity of research ethics committees to respond effectively during outbreaks. About 25 representatives of ethics bodies, ministries and regulatory agencies participated.

Tools and technical guidance

In 2025 the WHO Regional Office for Europe continued to strengthen the Region's evidence and policy landscape by publishing new tools, guidance and research to support countries in advancing safe, effective and people-centred digital transformation. These

outputs addressed emerging challenges in data governance, telemedicine, workforce readiness, cybersecurity and the ethical adoption of AI, while expanding the scientific foundation for digital health policies across the Region.



Discover the policy brief [25]



Discover the policy brief [26]



Discover the policy brief [27]



Discover the policy brief [28]

The Regional Office published four policy briefs addressing priority issues in digital health. The brief on health data governance in the age of AI [25] set out urgent actions to strengthen governance, interoperability and stakeholder engagement. *Scaling up telemedicine in the WHO European Region* [26] examined the uneven integration of telehealth into routine practice and highlighted the need for stronger evaluation and system-wide readiness.

Accelerating the uptake of digital solutions by the health and care workforce in the WHO European Region [27] identified persistent barriers to digital adoption and outlined policy options to build digital skills and confidence. The final brief, *Addressing the digital determinants of youth mental health and well-being* [28], led by the Mental Health team, called for coordinated action to create safer, healthier and more equitable digital environments for young people.



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New scientific studies further enriched the evidence base for digital transformation. A scoping review (29) demonstrated how digital health technologies improve women's health, empowerment and gender equality. Research on radiology (30) highlighted AI's potential to significantly reduce workloads while preserving essential human expertise. A special issue of the International Journal

of Medical Informatics (31) explored digital transformation across the Region and identified barriers and opportunities for building more resilient, interoperable systems. Additional work examined technology-facilitated violence against women (32) and the critical role of health systems in responding to this.



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The Regional Office released several technical documents to guide Member States in strengthening digital health systems. The new guidance offers practical support for assessing and improving cybersecurity (33) in an increasingly vulnerable sector. A WHO study on dementia care (34) shows how telemedicine can reduce anxiety, loneliness and safety risks while supporting carers.

To advance shared learning, the Regional Office also launched two Knowledge Communities, one on responsible AI in health (35) and another, jointly with the United Kingdom's Medicines and Healthcare products Regulatory Agency, on regulating digital mental health technologies (36) to provide platforms to navigate complex questions of evidence, safety and trust.

Support to countries

In 2025 the WHO Regional Office for Europe continued to provide tailored support to Member States across the Region by helping them strengthen data governance, digital health systems, evidence-informed policy-making and health information infrastructure. This included training courses, assessments, technical missions, presentations, facilitation of national discussions, participation in conferences, and reviewing strategic and operational plans.

Throughout the year, countries drew on WHO expertise to advance their national priorities. In Armenia and Latvia, WHO carried out health information system assessments requested by the ministries of health that focused on digitalization and data governance to inform national digital health strategies, respectively. In Portugal, joint WHO teams conducted an interoperability and health information system assessment mission that engaged public and private stakeholders and produced a consolidated report for national authorities. Slovenia benefited from an AI-assisted review of its National Health Plan (37) and support in drafting the new plan for 2026–2036.

Several countries requested support in digital and evidence-informed policy

implementation. Bosnia and Herzegovina worked with WHO to integrate telemedicine into primary health care and Romania received technical support on digital health. Georgia and Tajikistan participated in capacity-building activities on system interoperability, data flow mapping and evidence-informed decision-making. Croatia received support to apply One Health approaches and Uzbekistan worked with WHO to strengthen its operational planning for evidence-informed reforms.

WHO also contributed to high-level national dialogues. In Czechia, the WHO Representative presented the latest evidence on telemedicine and in Germany, WHO delivered a keynote address on population health surveillance at the Robert Koch Institute. In Serbia and Turkmenistan, WHO supported country engagement by providing analyses of digital health developments, national health trends and future areas for technical collaboration, including training in clinical guideline development and NCD management.

These activities reflect the Regional Office's commitment to meeting countries where they are and providing practical, context-specific support to strengthen health systems and advance safe, effective and equitable digital transformation across the Region.

Events and capacity-building activities

In 2025 the WHO Regional Office for Europe organized and supported a series of high-level events and capacity-building activities across the Region focused on AI, health

information systems, interoperability, electronic health records and the use of data for decision-making.



A major milestone was the high-level meeting “AI for Health and Care in Europe: Practical Solutions for a Healthy Future” (38), which was co-hosted with Malta and supported by the European Commission. The event brought together senior officials from 41 Member States across the Region to discuss how

AI is reshaping health systems (39) and explore practical, ethical and people-centred approaches for its deployment. The meeting followed the launch of a landmark report on AI’s impact on health planning, delivery and governance (6).





The Regional Office also strengthened its collaboration with Portugal through a new initiative to build national capacity for AI use in health. This work was showcased at the regional dialogue, “Health, humanity and AI:

building a responsible future” (40), held in Porto that had more than 260 participants representing governments, public health institutions and digital health experts.

Watch the video recording of this event (41).



Capacity-building efforts continued across multiple domains. The Regional Office advanced its work with the WHO Family of International Classifications (42) and delivered a consolidated programme of training courses and webinars on digital health. The Decoding Data and Digital Health webinar series (43), supported by the European Commission, addressed AI use in electronic health records, workforce optimization and digital determinants of

health, while a joint WHO–Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development webinar explored emerging telemedicine frameworks and good practices.

All recordings are available in this YouTube playlist (44)



In parallel, WHO coordinated training initiatives for Member States, including the fourth cohort of Big Data and AI Impact Training (45) under the Small Countries Initiative (46), two editions of the Population Health Surveillance Training (47) in Denmark,

and regional workshops on data visualization and Microsoft Power BI in Kyrgyzstan. Additional sessions in Georgia supported the integration of knowledge translation, Microsoft Power BI and responsible AI use into health policy-making.



These events strengthened national capacities, advanced regional dialogue and equipped countries with the skills and

evidence needed to navigate a rapidly evolving digital health landscape.

Agreements and partnerships

The EU remained one of the WHO Regional Office for Europe's most important partners in 2025. Cooperation continued through the joint EU-WHO project (19) to support Member States in strengthening health information systems and health data governance, which runs until July 2027. This collaboration is advancing knowledge exchange through two new Knowledge Communities on responsible AI use in health and digital mental health regulation, as well as regional events, consultations and experience-sharing workshops. Capacity-building remained a core component, with more than 1100 participants joining webinars and over 100 experts trained in areas such as population health surveillance, big data, the 11th revision of the International Classification of Diseases, data visualization and Microsoft Power BI. The project has also supported technical guidance on cybersecurity, health data governance, telemedicine and women's digital health, alongside health information system assessments in Armenia and Latvia and annual updates to key regional databases.



The Regional Office also deepened partnerships across the Region. A donor agreement with Italy through National Agency for Regional Health Services launched WHO support for development of the Italian National Digital Health Strategy. Four new collaborating centres were designated in 2025: Deggendorf Institute of Technology in Germany (48) and the Open University of Catalonia in Spain (49) to advance digital health policy and implementation; Public Health Wales (50) to support work on digital health equity; and Humanitas University in Italy (51) to strengthen evidence-informed decision-making. These centres expand the Regional Office's capacity to generate knowledge, provide training and evaluate digital health solutions.

The Strategic Partners' Initiative for Data and Digital Health (52) completed its first cohort by bringing together stakeholders from the public and private sectors. Over 18 months, four working groups delivered practical outputs, including synthesized AI case studies, an implementation framework for prevention and care in the home, an interoperability compass for policy-makers, and an AI-driven blueprint for identifying workforce burnout risks. A repository of digital health case studies (53), developed with the WHO Collaborating Centre in Norway, further supported shared learning across the Region.

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